LEARN Journal 2 (Due: October 20, 2026)

L – Look Back

- Translating Customer Discovery into Usable System Design

E – Elaborate

- Throughout the middle of October, our focus shifted toward customer validation. Using the 10-question interview framework from HELIX EWIL Workbook 5, I conducted one-on-one discovery sessions with veteran simulation and tabletop RPG gamers recruited from Reddit and Discord. I went into these interviews highly confident that players would be thrilled by our game's ability to expose every granular mathematical variable behind NPC choices through floating UI tooltips. However, during our very first screen-share playtest with an experienced *RimWorld* player, the feedback was completely humbling. Within five minutes, the tester became overwhelmed by the sheer volume of numbers, modifiers, and raw coefficient calculations cluttering the screen. He remarked, "I want to understand why this character betrayed me, but reading a college algebra equation every time an NPC speaks destroys the drama." I initially felt defensive and attempted to explain the algorithmic sophistication behind the data, but subsequent interviews with four other participants revealed the exact same issue: transparency had turned into cognitive exhaustion.

A – Analyze

- I had conflated transparency with raw data dumps. In my passion for mathematical rigor, I designed the interface from an engineer's diagnostic perspective rather than a player's experiential perspective. Furthermore, my initial defensiveness during the first interview showed that I was seeking validation for my technical choices rather than genuinely listening to customer pain points. This misjudgment risked alienating our core user demographic.

R – Revised Approach

- I took immediate initiative to redesign the information hierarchy. Instead of displaying multi-step formula derivations by default, I structured the tooltips into intuitive causal chains (e.g., *Personality Trait + Recent Event -> Behavioral Outcome*), tucking the advanced mathematical breakdown behind an optional expandable view. Additionally, I committed to conducting future interviews with an objective, neutral mindset, asking open-ended clarifying questions instead of defending existing prototypes.

N – New Perspective

- I learned that user-centered software engineering requires ruthless empathy. Technical depth should empower the user, not burden them. True transparency does not mean displaying every raw calculation; it means communicating complex logic with such clarity that the end user feels in control. Listening openly to critical feedback is far more valuable to product success than protecting one's technical ego.